

▶ **“THE LIMIT OF ONDC (Open Network for Digital Commerce) is the limit of our own imagination,” says Gopal Srinivasan, Chairman and MD of TVS Capital. His words never rang truer than when Kudumbashree, a Kerala government-supported organisation of women’s neighbourhood groups, joined the initiative this March.**

For the first time in its 25 years of existence, women entrepreneurs among Kudumbashree’s 4.5 million members will have their products available for purchase online across India. The integration of organisations like Kudumbashree into ONDC is a natural fit for its core value—address the inadequacies of India’s digital commerce ecosystem and establish a level-playing field for small-scale vendors to thrive.

24 | “Everybody is excited about its possibilities,” says a visibly charged-up T. Koshy, CEO of ONDC, during an hour-long interview with *BT* at its new August Kranti Marg office in south Delhi. “When UPI was launched, everyone said it is a developing country problem. Today, everyone accepts it is the best in the world. When it comes to digital commerce, the market concentration and associated practices which are detrimental to the industry in general and small industry in particular, are a problem globally.” A veteran technocrat, the 62-year-old Koshy has worked on several digital infrastructure initiatives such as National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) and Aadhaar, besides having a decade-long stint with consulting biggie EY.

While word on the street is that ONDC wants to shake things up and take on the big dogs of e-commerce, people behind it see it more like a massive digital party where buyers, sellers and logistics providers can all hang out and do business together. “I see ONDC as a force of inclusion,” says Nandan Nilekani, Co-founder and Chairman of IT services major Infosys, and also a member of ONDC’s advisory council, adding that a bulk of India’s retail is with small retail establishments, and while modern retail and large e-commerce players can leverage digital capability, small players cannot. “It is not about him digitising his shop. Rather, it is about participating in an ecosystem that ONDC will enable. Ev-



PHOTO BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

“LOOK AT ANY LARGE PUBLIC GOOD PROJECT. IT TAKES TIME FOR SOCIAL TRANSFORMATION TO HAPPEN... WHAT WE ARE DOING IS PRIMING OF THE PUMP; IT WILL GROW FROM THERE NATURALLY”

T. KOSHY

CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER, ONDC